

Neoclassicism

Partly in reaction to the frivolity of the Rococo, and partly developing from the ideas of the Enlightenment, Neoclassicism was particularly inspired by the discovery in the mid-18th century of Pompeii and Herculaneum – two ancient Roman cities buried beneath the volcanic ash of the eruption of Mount Vesuvius in 79 CE. Such preservation of art and architecture reignited a belief in ancient Greek and Roman virtues such as courage and patriotism, and motivated contemporary artists and architects to follow similarly clean lines and contours.

Neoclassicism was also closely linked with changing politics in France. Ennobling and inspiring themes of sacrifice and heroism prevailed. The movement's most influential figures were David, Ingres and Anton Raphael Mengs (1728–79). Among sculptors, Jean-Antoine Houdon (1741–1828) is renowned for his portrait busts and statues of Enlightenment philosophers, inventors and political figures, while Antonio Canova (1757–1822) from Venice, is famous for refined marble sculptures that delicately render flesh.



David, *Oath of the Horatii*, 1786